

The Demise of Local Journalism and Democratic Health in Canada*

Jet McCullough

William Chan

June 18, 2026

1 Context & Literature Review

Local journalism has been consistently declining in Canada. A 2025 report found that 2.5 million Canadians live in areas with almost no local news coverage, and the remaining outlets continue to face the threat of closure (Macdonald 2025). Lindgren (2019) argues that local news acts as a “civic watchdog” that helps residents evaluate politicians in their ridings by scrutinizing the records of local candidates and incumbents. The demise of local journalism is thus detrimental to the health of democracy in Canada.

The crisis of local news deprivation is not unique to Canada. Haddock et al. (2026) found a similar trend in the United States, where the number of counties without local news doubled to more than 200 between 2010 and 2016. This decline is associated with increases in non-violent crime, lower voter turnout, and greater political polarization (Haddock et al. 2026), as residents rely more heavily on national media, which tends to be more partisan and less focused on local issues, thereby amplifying ideological divisions and political apathy toward local politics.

Likewise, Moskowitz (2021) argues that elections have become more nationalized in the United States as voters increasingly rely on national, partisan media to assess the performance of politicians. Greater local news coverage leads to higher levels of voter knowledge about local incumbents and candidates, allowing voters to make assessments that differ from their “national judgement on the presidential race” in the form of split-ticket voting (p. 126). Moskowitz (2021) posits that highly nationalized elections undermine the accountability of officeholders, as their performance is more likely to be judged by the popularity of their party and president rather than by their competence and service delivery (p. 127).

Echoing Moskowitz (2021), Ellger et al. (2024) provides evidence from Germany, where they found that the disappearance of local news is correlated with an increase in the vote share of

*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/jethroid/INF2167-Proposal-Group-2>.

small parties. In the German party system, small parties tend to be further from the ideological center; thus, an increase in their vote shares indicates greater polarization among the electorate (p. 1266).

2 Research Questions

Scholarly studies on news deprivation and its political implications mostly focus on the U.S. context, thereby revealing a research gap in the Canadian context. Drawing from existing literature, we propose two research questions:

RQ1. Do Canadian ridings with lower levels of local news coverage exhibit lower voter turnout?

H1: Ridings that experience a decline in local news coverage will exhibit lower voter turnout.

RQ2. Is the decline of local news in Canada associated with higher levels of political polarization?

H2: Ridings that experience a decline in local news coverage will exhibit higher levels of political polarization.

3 Dataset and Methods

We will be relying on datasets from two sources. One dataset we will be using is from the Local News Map, published by the Local News Research Project (citation). As part of this project, raw data is published every two months with updates on changes to local media outlets, each report ranging from the present day back to 2008 when the project was started. There are three key variables in this dataset for the purposes of answering our research questions. One is “transition type”: the project maps positive changes (new papers, increases in service) as well as negative, and we will be specifically studying the impact of a reduction in local media. The other two key variables are “date of change” and “community” (i.e. city, town, etc.), which are important as we will be comparing these changes to election results over time and by region.

The other dataset we will be using

4 Exploratory Data Analysis

References

- Ellger, Fabio, Hanno Hilbig, Sascha Riaz, and Philipp Tillmann. 2024. “Local Newspaper Decline and Political Polarization – Evidence from a Multi-Party Setting.” *British Journal of Political Science* 54 (4): 1256–75. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0007123424000243>.
- Haddock, Tess, K. Aleks Schaefer, Brian E. Whitacre, and Trey Malone. 2026. “Local News Deserts and Community Social Capital Erosion.” *Journal of Regional Science* 66 (2): 626–49. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jors.70053>.
- Lindgren, April. 2019. “What the Death of Local News Means for the Federal Election.” *The Walrus*, April. <https://thewalrus.ca/what-the-death-of-local-news-means-for-the-federal-election/>.
- Macdonald, Sonja. 2025. “Local News Media Is Declining in Canada—We Have to Reverse the Trend.” *Canadian Centre for Policy Alternatives*, July. <https://www.policyalternatives.ca/news-research/local-news-media-is-declining-in-canada-we-have-to-reverse-the-trend/>.
- Moskowitz, Daniel J. 2021. “Local News, Information, and the Nationalization of U.S. Elections.” *American Political Science Review* 115 (1): 114–29. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055420000829>.